

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1991-10-28

To an individual bahá'í

1 dear bahá'í friend,
2 . . . The house of justice was deeply touched by the spirit of your letter,
3 warmly congratulates you on the status you have attained as an academic,
4 and appreciates your efforts to make use of your scholarly training in lending
expression to the faith in academic circles.

The requirement that materials about the faith authored by bahá'ís

5 must be reviewed by bahá'í institutions before publication is imbedded in
6 a bahá'í administrative policy which originated with the explicit instruc-
7 tion of 'Abdu'l-bahá. Shoghi effendi included this instruction in his outline
8 of the duties of National Spiritual Assemblies, and the duty of reviewing bahá'í
material is included in the constitution of these institutions with
9 his approval. The requirement is temporary and is meant to protect the
10 interests of the faith at the early stages of its development.
11 you are, of course, entirely correct that only the guardian had the pre-
12 rogative of interpretation; it is not a prerogative that he could have devolved
13 on other institutions. yet in a number of letters written on his behalf, the
14 importance of reviewing manuscripts about the faith was repeatedly em-
15 phasized, such as in a letter dated 15 November 1956 written to an individual, in
which the following is stated:¹¹⁷ .2

118 1

118 2

118 3

119 1986-1992 • The Six Year Plan

120 21 Any bahá'í book presenting the faith should be reviewed by a compe-

tent body. This only means that they should ascertain whether there

121 is any misrepresentation of the Teachings in it. Sometimes the friends
122 think they have to go into literary reviews and interfere with the au-thor's style etc.,
123 which of course is wholly unnecessary. . . .

123 118-1

124 clearly, then, there is a distinction between the function of interpretation for which
125 Shoghi effendi was solely responsible and the function of bahá'í

125 review, which is essentially a matter of judgment. literary review is, of
126 course, a separate matter.

127 The house of justice feels certain that it is possible for scholars to abide
128 by this requirement without undermining the academic standard of their
129 work, since the purpose of review is not inimical to academic excellence.

130 your concerns as an academic certainly deserve careful attention. but the

bahá'í community also has immense concerns about the consequences of

131 dispensing too quickly with this requirement. The bahá'í faith makes very
132 serious claims and has a rich and complex history, but it is as yet a young religion
133 whose precepts are not widely understood. it has been undergoing

133 severe persecution in the land of its birth and is experiencing serious op-
134 position in other places where its detractors have no compunction in mis-
135 representing its purposes. until its history, teachings and practices are well
136 known throughout the world, it will be necessary for the bahá'í community
137 to make efforts within itself to present correct information about the faith

138 in published material. This can and must be done without violating the principle of
139 freedom of expression, which, according to the teachings of the faith, is a vital right of all
140 persons.

even in the world of journalism where the most libertine excesses of

139 expression are stoutly defended on the grounds of constitutional protection, as is the
140 case in the united States, serious questions are being raised about

140 the accuracy of nonfiction books being published these days. An article in a
141 recent issue of Columbia Journalism Review (july / August 1991), that bastion
142 of freedom of expression, devoted attention to such questions, querying the

143 responsibility of publishers and editors and commenting on the sloppiness of some
144 writers. it encourages reviewers of inaccurate books to take the

144 publishers to task and to expose the authors' transgressions, pointing out,

145 118-1. ldg, p. 120.118.3a

118 4

118 5

119 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

120 22by quoting one such reviewer, that: "A newspaper can report one thing one

121 day and revise or revoke the report the next day; a book makes a promise of

122 much longer duration and far greater authority. The scale and presentation

123 make a vital difference." but this has to do with review after publication.

124 Among its suggestions for prepublication solutions to inaccuracy, the article offers
the following thought to publishers: "They could pay in-house or

125 outside researchers to request documentation from the author, then judge

126 its worthiness. At the very least, they could pay for a spot check, then decide whether
a full-scale review is necessary."

127 The positions you have taken in the third paragraph of your letter indi-

128 cate an overreaction and a misconception of the real purpose of bahá'í re-

129 view. is it not possible for bahá'í academics to acknowledge the merit of the

130 intention of this temporary requirement and, recognizing the sensitivity of

131 the matter in view of the attitudes of the academic community, assist them-

132 selves and the bahá'í institutions to find a balance between both academic

133 and bahá'í expectations? bahá'í review is not an exercise in censorship; it is

134 in large measure a benefit offered to an author by the bahá'í institutions,

135 which are, in fact, the major repositories of the source materials that ordi-narily
constitute the wellspring of the author's work and are for other reasons the channels of
elucidation for a wide range of obscure questions relating to the faith. certainly, a
dispassionate exploration by bahá'í scholars of the

136 issues concerning both the academic community and the bahá'í institutions

137 in this matter could result in the formulation of a rationale appropriate to aiding
understanding in academic circles as to the nature and necessity of

138 bahá'í review. bahá'í academics, after all, are, first and foremost, believers in

139 the cause of g od and upholders of divine law.

The house of justice has acknowledged in the past that the process of

140 review is often irksome, frequently takes far too long and is subject to many problems
in implementation. Nevertheless, it is convinced that this is not

141 the time to remove this temporary procedure. National Spiritual Assemblies
responsible for administering the reviewing procedure have been urged to do all they can to
improve and expedite its operation, and efforts are con-

142 tinually being made to this end. The house of justice looks forward to the
143 day when this requirement will be definitely removed; in the meantime it
144 may well be modified as conditions change.

145 with regard to your particular concerns, there is nothing in the current
146 regulations that would prevent a scholar who has written a work to recom-mend to
the National Spiritual Assembly one or more individuals whom he 118.6

118 7

118 8

119 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

120 2would like to see included among the reviewers selected by the Assembly.

121 This approach offers the author a way of satisfying himself that he has had
122 a direct part in the arrangement for review, and he can take confidence that
123 some measure of peer review has been invested in the procedure.

124 The house of justice trusts that this procedure will reduce your concerns
125 and assures you of its prayers on your behalf in the h oly Shrines.

126 with loving b ahá'í greetings,

Department of tHe secretariat

127 119

Selecting Reviewers for Bahá'í Manuscripts

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]